

CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

BJP'S NEW FORMULA FOR SUCCESS

As the election results started pouring in on March 10, it soon became apparent that the Modi+Yogi combination had proved to be a highly successful formula for the BJP. The party secured a landslide majority, winning 255 seats on its own and 273 with allies out of the 403 seats in the assembly. That was historic: no chief minister in the state had ever won a re-election after completing a full term in office. Nor has any incumbent government been voted to power a second time since 1985. Though the BJP could not replicate its 2017 feat of winning 312 seats on its own (and 325 with allies), the victory was highly creditable as it came after two devastating years of the Covid-19 pandemic. Joblessness ran high, as did inflation, and the state's farmers were unhappy over the Centre's contentious agriculture laws.

There was also the spirited challenge from former chief minister Akhilesh Yadav, who not only managed to unite the Samajwadi Party but also built a successful campaign around the narrative that the BJP government had neglected the backward classes, which comprise nearly a third of the state's population. This is what enabled Akhilesh to lure three of Yogi's OBC ministers into the SP while also tying up with a handful of other parties representing these castes. Yet, as the India Today-Axis My India exit poll presciently predicted, the BJP swept the state, cutting across caste, gender and age groups, exposing a strong but silent pro-incumbency undercurrent that contributed to the huge saffron success (*see accompanying report*).

If the party has returned to power in four of the five states that went to the polls in this round, the secret, says Pradeep Gupta, CMD of the Axis My India agency, lay simply in 'Delivery'. "There is no way people will re-elect a party unless they believe it has performed," he says. "That's true for all the four BJP-ruled states, including UP, which returned the party to power. All had seen setbacks caused by the pandemic. But besides state-level development policies, it was the delivery of the various welfare schemes launched by the Modi government that proved decisive, whether in terms of quantity, quality or timelines."

RSS ideologue Ram Madhav acknowledges this as well. "What this round of polls proves is that the old politics of dynasty, religion and opportunistic alliances no longer cuts ice with the electorate," he says. "It is the beneficiaries of good governance that spoke up in these BJP-ruled states. It is a sign of the maturity of the Indian voter. It will put the onus on leaders to perform and deliver." In Punjab, voters seemed disillusioned with the performance of the incumbent Congress government, and voted overwhelmingly for the Aam Aadmi Party, giving it a stunning mandate of 92 seats in the 117-member House.

UP, UP AFTER UP?

For the BJP, the win in UP is crucial for several reasons. For one, as Modi himself said in his victory speech at the BJP headquarters in Delhi, "I hope pundits will now have the courage to say that the 2022 UP results have decided the 2024 Lok Sabha results." The accompanying wins in Goa, Uttarakhand and Manipur will ensure there are no hiccups for its nominee in the presidential election in July. The BJP and its allies will now have enough votes in the electoral college (a mix of elected representatives of both houses of Parliament besides elected members of state legislatures) to secure a win for its nominee.

The four-state victory is also expected to boost the BJP's confidence

IN YOGI, MODI SEES A KINDRED SPIRIT, WHO, LIKE HIM, IS DEVOTED TO A CAUSE, HAS NO FAMILY TO PROMOTE AND IS SEEN AS INCORRUPTIBLE

in the other states going to election. These include the Gujarat and Himachal Pradesh polls later this year, followed by assembly polls for Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Telangana, Chhattisgarh and the four northeastern states in 2023. The BJP plans to celebrate 100 years of the founding of the RSS, its ideological mentor, in 2025 in emphatic style, for which a win in the next general election is a must.

One significant outcome of the current round of assembly elections is that it has silenced critics who be-